

Coding Manual: Fact Link's Deepfake Study

1. Introduction to Manual Coding

Manual coding involves the systematic classification of textual data based on predefined categories. The goal is to extract political sentiment, rhetorical strategies, and signs of manipulation.

1.1 Entity-Centered Sentiment

Coders must identify the specific entity or object toward which sentiment is directed. A comment may express anger or sarcasm, but the target of that emotion must be clearly identified.

- Focus on sentiment directed at entities (e.g., Taiwan, China, USA), not general tone.
- Detect indirect or implied sentiment (e.g., irony, sarcasm).
- Disaggregate sentiment when multiple entities are mentioned.

1.2 Appraisal Theory Framework

Appraisal Theory (Martin & White, 2005) guides the annotation of political opinion expression. It includes:

A. Attitude

- *Affect*: Emotional responses (e.g., joy, fear, anger).
- *Judgment*: Moral evaluations (e.g., corrupt, brave).
- *Appreciation*: Aesthetic or value-based assessments (e.g., effective, chaotic).

B. Engagement

- *Monoglossic*: No recognition of alternative views.
- *Heteroglossic*: Acknowledges other perspectives (e.g., "some say...").

C. Graduation

- *Force*: Intensity of expression (e.g., "very dangerous").
- *Focus*: Prototypicality (e.g., "a real threat").

This framework is meant to orient coders, giving a list of clues on what to look for in a comment's language to assess sentiment. This is only meant to help, not obligatory to use.

2. Coding Categories

Each comment is coded for the presence or absence of the following categories. Use binary coding (Yes/No).

2.1 Taiwanese Nationalism

Definition: Expressions of pride, support, or identification with Taiwan's civic, democratic, or cultural identity.

Indicators:

- Support for democratic institutions, civil rights, and civic engagement.
- Positive references to protests, NGOs, free media, or legislative activism.
- Emphasis on inclusive civic identity, including indigenous, migrant, and urban narratives.
- Cultural pride that acknowledges Chinese heritage without subordinating Taiwanese identity.
- Expressions of solidarity with other democratic movements (e.g., Hong Kong).
- Mentions of Taiwan's peaceful approach to sovereignty and preference for self-rule.
- References of Taiwanese people being good, moral characters (e.g., Taiwanese friendliness")
- References to Taiwanese people having a strong moral compass

Coding:

- *Yes:* Comment affirms or celebrates Taiwanese civic nationalism.
- *No:* No such affirmation or comment opposes Taiwanese nationalism.

2.2 Antipathy Towards China

Definition: Expressions of hostility, distrust, or rejection of China's political system, intentions, or influence.

Indicators:

- References to censorship, authoritarianism, or suppression of dissent under the CCP.
- Comparisons to Hong Kong or Ukraine used to highlight perceived threats.
- Historical grievances (e.g., 228 massacre, martial law, cultural suppression).
- Opposition to integration with China framed as a security or identity concern.
- Descriptions of China as a threat to Taiwan's autonomy or democratic values.
- Critiques of China's military drills, diplomatic coercion, or grey-zone tactics.
- Negative evaluations of China's political trajectory under Xi Jinping.
- Expressions of dissatisfaction or dislike towards Chinese society or citizens.
- Comments lamenting the corruption of Chinese society.
- References to Chinese citizens lack of morality.

Coding:

- *Yes*: Comment expresses antipathy toward China or its political model.
- *No*: No such sentiment or neutral/positive view of China.

2.3 Antipathy Towards Taiwan

Definition: Expressions aimed at delegitimizing Taiwan's governance, society, or international standing.

Indicators:

- Claims of corruption, incompetence, or systemic policy failure.
- Fabricated scandals or exaggerated crises (e.g., pension reform lies).
- Personal attacks on democratic leaders, e.g.: on DPP officials .
- Portrayal of Taiwan as internationally isolated or diplomatically irrelevant.
- Depictions of Taiwanese society as chaotic, criminal, or culturally decaying.
- Expressions of dissatisfaction or dislike towards Taiwanese society or citizens.
- References to Taiwanese citizens lack of morality.
- Suggestions that unification with China would solve Taiwan's problems.
- Attempts to discourage foreign sympathy, investment, or tourism.

Coding:

- *Yes*: Comment undermines Taiwan's legitimacy or expresses hostility.
- *No*: No such sentiment or neutral/positive view of Taiwan.

2.4 Questioning the Authenticity of the Video

Definition: Comments that challenge the truthfulness or credibility of the deepfake video.

Indicators:

- Phrases like "This is fake", "Check your facts", "Debunked", "AI-generated".
- References to deepfake technology, manipulation techniques, or misinformation.
- Irony or ridicule directed at the video's claims or production quality.
- Warnings to other viewers not to trust the video or its message.
- Comments citing external sources or personal expertise to refute the video.
- Polarized reactions within the comment section (e.g., debate over authenticity).
- Observations about the nature of the manipulation itself (e.g., voice mismatch, visual glitches).
- Statements indicating that
 - The video is generated by AI
 - The video is fake (without specifying how the video was produced)

- The content of the video is not true or that the video is unrealistic (for example, comments saying that the event portrayed in the video did not happen or could not possibly happen in Taiwan).

Coding:

- *Yes*: Comment questions the video's authenticity.
- *No*: No such challenge or comment accepts video at face value.

2.5 Attitude Toward Other Countries (Excluding China)

Definition: Evaluation of foreign countries or international actors mentioned in the comment.

Coding Options:

Positive Indicators:

- Praise for countries with strong ties to Taiwan (e.g., USA, Japan, EU).
- Support for political, military, or economic cooperation.
- References to shared democratic values or ideals ("free world", "like-minded partners").
- Endorsement of Taiwan's inclusion in international organizations.
- Expressions of mutual benefit or joint efforts for peace and prosperity.
- Trust in another country's willingness, reliability or capability to defend Taiwan in case of existential threat (e.g: War) .
- Trust in military allies.

Negative Indicators:

- Claims of foreign interference, manipulation, or abandonment.
- Critiques of overreliance on one country for defense or trade.
- Assertions that Taiwan is used as a pawn or sacrificed by allies.
- Denunciations of adversarial powers or biased international bodies.
- Objections to unequal partnerships or exploitative globalization.
- Skepticism of another country's willingness, reliability or capability to assist or defend Taiwan in case of existential threat (e.g: War) .
- Lack of trust in military allies.

Neutral Indicators:

- Factual reporting of diplomatic events, treaties, or policies.
- Balanced discussion of pros and cons of foreign relations.
- Emphasis on pragmatic or non-aligned foreign policy.
- Recognition of complexity or uncertainty without taking sides.

Coding:

- *Positive*: Comment expresses favorable views of foreign countries or alliances.

- *Negative*: Comment expresses critical or hostile views of foreign countries.
- *Neutral*: Comment presents a balanced or factual perspective.

Note: Evaluate based on tone and context, not just country mentioned.

2.6 Signs of Coordinated Inauthentic Behavior

Definition: Indicators that a comment may be part of a coordinated or automated campaign.

Indicators:

- Repetitive or formulaic comments across multiple threads.
- Identical or near-identical phrasing (e.g., “Great video! Keep it up!”).
- Slight variations with the same core message or structure.
- Awkward grammar, robotic tone, or machine-translated phrasing.
- Overuse of generic praise without contextual relevance.
- Excessive hashtags or spam links, especially repeated across comments.
- Calls to action (“like”, “subscribe”, “watch till the end”) in identical phrasing.
- Language switching or mixed scripts within a single comment.
- Identity claims (“I’m not a bot”, “just a normal viewer”) used to deflect suspicion.
- Unusual frequency of praise directed at the channel itself rather than content.

Coding:

- *Yes*: Comment shows one or more signs of inauthentic coordination.
- *No*: Comment appears organic and contextually grounded.

2.7 Agreement with the video's statement

Agreement

- The comment approves the content of the video
- The comment praises the content of the video
- The comment expressing thoughts or ideas aligned with the video
- The comment gives examples as supporting evidence of the video

Disagreement

- Disapprove of the content of the video
- The comment criticizes the content of the video
- The comment provides evidence that is against the content of the video

Neutral

- The comment does not express agreement or disagreement.
- The comment talks about irrelevant topics.

Coding:

- Agree
- Disagree
- Neutral

3. Final Notes for Coders

- Always read comments in full and consider context.
- Use annotation notes for ambiguous cases.
- When in doubt, consult with project lead or refer to examples.
- Maintain consistency across coding sessions.